

Research Overview

Model UN Preparation Guide The first step in preparing for a rewarding Model UN experience is to gather information. Give yourself plenty of time before a conference to research, read and then formulate your arguments. Since most delegates use the Internet for about majority of their research, UNA-USA has compiled a list of [web resources](#) to help you get started. However, you should not overlook the resources available in books and periodicals at your local library. While conducting research, try to keep in mind that your primary goal is to represent your country as realistically as possible. To do so, you will need to research three different areas. Follow these links for tips on researching each of the three components:

- Your [country](#) and its positions;
- The [issues](#) to be debated at the conference; and
- The [UN system](#).

Collecting Country Information | Research Overview

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First, you will need to learn about your country so you can address the issues raised at the conference as a real UN delegate from that country. To represent your country accurately, start by answering the following questions:

- What sort of government does your country have?
- What types of ideologies (political, religious or other) influence your country's government?
- Which domestic issues might influence your country's foreign policy?
- What are some major events in your country's history? Why are they important?
- Which ethnicities, religions and languages can be found in your country?
- Where is your country located and how does its geography affect its political relationships?
- Which countries share a border with your country?
- Which countries are considered allies of your country?
- Which countries are considered enemies of your country?
- What are the characteristics of your country's economy?
- What is your country's gross domestic product (GDP)? How does this compare to other countries in the world?

- When did your country become a member of the UN?
- Does your country belong to any [intergovernmental organizations](#) outside the UN system such as the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) or the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC)?
- Does your country belong to any regional organizations such as the European Union (EU), the African Union (AU) or the Organization of American States (OAS)?
- Does your country belong to any trade organizations or agreements such as the North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA) or the Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD)?

Tips for Researching Your Country

Look up your country's [permanent mission](#) to the UN. You can also call the mission directly to ask questions or request a position statement on an issue.

Find your country's voting records and read speeches on the [United Nations Bibliographic Information System](#) website.

Look at the [CIA World Factbook](#) for a general overview on your country, and for figures and statistics as well. The World Factbook is produced by the United States Central Intelligence Agency (CIA). Would your country's government agree with the way your country is characterized in the World Factbook?

Check out [news and media](#) sources for recent developments in your country.

Read the US State Department report on your country. Call the US State Department desk officer for your country to find out more about conditions there.

Researching Conference Topics | Research Overview Model UN Preparation Guide

Next, you should develop an understanding of the issues that will be debated at your Model UN conference. Many conferences send out background materials or issue briefs, which can help jumpstart your research. You may want to look at the sources cited in these materials for more in-depth information. If the conference background materials pose questions, you should answer them with your country information in mind. Here are some additional questions to help guide your research:

- What is the problem? How does it affect your country?
- What has your country done to combat the problem?
- What are the various “sides” in the debate?
- Which aspects of the issue are most important to your country?
- If your country is not involved with the issue, how can it become involved?
- How will your country shape the debate at the conference?
- What arguments will other countries make?
- How do the positions of other countries affect your country’s position?
- Is there evidence or statistics that might help to back up your country’s position?

Tips for Researching Issues

Check out [news and media sources](#) for up-to-date developments on an issue. Ask your community, school or university librarian if you can get access to LexisNexis Academic Universe. LexisNexis is a system that searches thousands of periodicals. Another service is Questia. This service costs about \$15.00 per month, but allows you to access thousands of documents from your personal computer.

Look at the [UN Economic and Social Development](#) page, which has an index to some prominent issues as well as a list of UN agencies that work in various issue-areas. Also, through the [United Nations Documentation Center](#), you can find resolutions and voting records from the current and previous years.

Visit [non-governmental organization \(NGO\) websites](#). NGOs are an important part of the UN system, in part due to the valuable research and information they generate. Look for NGOs that address your topic.

Read [academic publications](#). Although they can be complex, they provide in-depth information on many issues. Professors, students and researchers are constantly conducting studies and publishing papers.

Researching the UN System | Research Overview Model UN Preparation Guide

Understanding the [UN system](#) will help you play your role realistically at a Model UN conference. It is important to understand which bodies and actors make up the UN system, what the UN can and cannot do, and how international issues are addressed by the UN. Here are some questions that will help get you started:

- What are the important elements of the UN Charter?
- What are the main bodies of the UN?
- How are the UN’s bodies and agencies organized?

- Which countries serve on the body or agency you are simulating?
- How does the body or agency you are simulating operate?
- What are the most recent UN actions on your issue?
- Why did past UN actions succeed or fail?
- What conferences and meetings have been held with regard to your issue?
- What have UN officials said about your issue?

Tips for Researching the UN

Visit the UN website at www.un.org. Read about current affairs on the [UN News](#) page. In addition, you should look at the [UN Cyberschoolbus](#) website, as well as UNA-USA's [guide](#) to using it.

Read one of the many books published by the UN. The UN publishes books with general UN information as well as specific reports, which can be purchased on their [website](#).